

After אברהם prepares to perform the עקדה, placing יצחק אבינו on the מזבח, the מלאך calls מלאך (22:11) וַיִּקְרָא אֵלָיו מֵאֵלֶּה ה' מִן הַשָּׁמַיִם וַיֹּאמֶר אֲבִרְהָם אֲבִרְהָם וַיֹּאמֶר הֲגִנִי (22:11). The תורה tells us that the מלאך called אברהם twice. The first time, it says (22:12) וַיֹּאמֶר אֵל תְּשַׁלַּח יָדְךָ אֶל הַנֶּעָר וְאֵל תַּעֲשֵׂה לוֹ מֵאוֹמֶה כִּי עֲתָה יָדַעְתִּי כִּי יִירָא אֱלֹהִים אֶתָּה וְלֹא תִשְׁכַּת אֶת בְּנֶךָ אֵת יְחִידְךָ מִמֶּנִּי. The מלאך tells him: “Don’t harm him, because now I know that you are ירא אלקים, for you did not withhold your son מִמֶּנִּי.”

Then, the מלאך calls out to אברהם a second time (22:15-17):

וַיִּקְרָא מֵלֶאדָה ה' אֶל אֲבֹרֵהֶם שְׁנֵית מִן הַשָּׁמַיִם: וַיֹּאמֶר בִּי נִשְׁבַּעְתִּי נֹאם ה' כִּי יַעַן אֲשֶׁר עָשִׂיתָ אֶת הַדָּבָר הַזֶּה וְלֹא תִשְׁכַּח אֶת בְּנֶךָ אֶת יְחִידֶךָ: כִּי בְרַח אֲבִירְכָה וְהִרְבֵּה אֲרִכָּה אֶת זְרַעֲךָ

The Vilna Gaon points out that there's a massive difference between the first calling of the מלאך to אברהם and the second. In the first the מלאך says, "You did not withhold your son מִמֶּנִּי - from me." Who is speaking here? The מלאך is speaking. But in the second ברכה, it says it is given *in the name of* ה'.

The גר"א asks a phenomenal קושיא: Why would the מלאך say מִמֶּנִּי, from me? Was אברהם offering יצחק to the מלאך? Certainly not. How could the מלאך say, “You did not withhold your son from me”?

The גר"א provides an answer that almost only the גר"א could say. We know that every time a person does a מצוה, it creates a מלאך, and the quality of that מלאך corresponds to the quality of the מצוה itself. What qualities contribute to a מצוה? אהבה, זריזות, יראה, כוונה - these aspects and others influence the quality of the מלאך created by the מצוה.

So who is speaking to אברהם אבינו now? The מלאך that was created through the מצוה of the עקדה. It is this מלאך who says, “Now I know that you are ירא אלקים, for you did not withhold your son מִמֶּנִּי - from me.” The מלאך is effectively saying, “Look at the level I represent; from my high מדרגה, you can see the greatness of the יראת שמים of אברהם אבינו.” How do you know that I know? מִמֶּנִּי - from me”. The quality of the מלאך created by the עקדה reflects the greatness of this מצוה.

This teaches us a profound מוסר. When we do מצות, we should invest in them to elevate their quality. The מדרגה of our מצות reflects the greatness of our achievements. If we put more כוונה, more time, more אהבת ה' and יראת ה', it translates into a greater מצוה. Whether or not our מצות create a מלאך is not the main point - although if the מדרש says so, we believe it. The lesson is about the quality of our מצות. Our מצות should express our deep כוונה, our אהבת ה' and יראת ה', and that way, they will be of the highest quality. In the זכות of those מצות, may הקדוש ברוך הוא grant us נחמות, ישיועות, and ביאת גואל צדק במהרה בימינו אמן!

